

How representations may invoke discourses and ideologies and position audiences

- Representations carry ideological significance and reflect the time in which the product was made. There is ideological significance to the way in which representations are constructed in *The Bridge* which positions the audience to look at social groups and issues in different ways, reflecting cultural shifts. For example, this episode explores the growing contemporary interest in gender and how it is more fluid and changing than in the past and is a subject for discussion.
- *The Bridge*, through the ways in which it constructs representations, constructs a feminist discourse that challenges sexist, patriarchal ideas, and values:
 - Women are not marginalised; they are active and central to the narrative
 - Women are not sexualised
 - Women are not portrayed in a domestic role or defined as carers or nurturers
 - The women in the programme challenge and/or subvert the typical social norms related to gender behaviour.
- The representations in *The Bridge* are influenced by contemporary attitudes and debates, and consequently audiences are positioned to consider how representations have changed over time to reflect changes in society.

The effect of social and cultural context on representations

The effect of historical context on representations

Representations of gender: Women/ Femininity

There are several representations of women in *The Bridge* which subvert and challenge the more typical representations of women in crime dramas. Whilst the victim is more typically female, in the detectives the representation of women is strong reflecting shifts in society, culture and audience expectations. These women include:

- Saga: this character breaks away from the more typical representation of a detective. She is often compared to the 'flawed' detective of film noir but could be more accurately described as 'different'. Whilst the actor and programme's creators have avoided attaching a label to Saga, in constructing this character more challenging, complex behaviours are explored. She is described on the BBC website for the programme as 'a hardcore investigator who is socially challenged.' (<https://www.bbc.co.uk/programmes/articles/I9KPrlQqjCN9lrtLSPGq9N/characters>)



- All aspects of this character are pared back to the minimum including her clothing, dialogue, and relationships with others. She responds very literally to situations and in conversations which creates humour at times.
- Interestingly, whilst her representation is constructed as a powerful female, there are characteristics of Saga that are more masculine, suggesting this has helped her to survive in a patriarchal world. Her stance and walk are masculine, she is active and dynamic, moving about a lot, she is unconcerned by conventionality, for example she is not worried about changing her t-shirt in the middle of the office. Her clothing is masculine, for example, the leather trousers, military style overcoat and neutral t-shirt.
- Her passive expression has become iconic and is shown in close up particularly when she is attempting to process several pieces of information and inter-relationships with colleagues. An example in this episode is when, late in the day and absorbed in the case, she asks John to find a map for her, Hans suggests that John needs to go home, this confuses Saga who replies, 'he's recently divorced and his ex-wife has the kids this week', illustrating her inability to comprehend anyone who has a life outside of the job. Saga continues to work through the night and the audience is rarely shown aspects of her life outside of work.
- Saga's construction allows the programme to explore a character who does not conform to social norms, but in doing so effectively represents a particular under/mis-represented social group. Saga struggles with social situations, she knows how she should behave, but finds this challenging, for example when she attempts to make small talk with Hanne. She also lacks empathy and does not read sensitive situations well; she thinks rationally and says whatever occurs to her at the time with limited awareness of its appropriateness. However, she is shown to